A RESOURCE FOR BUSINESSES

BUSINESS LINK BL

Vol. 76 · Issue 10
October 2026

INFORMED. INSPIRED. CONNECTED.

Open for Business Events

Niagara Falls Tourism Connect: strong 2026 results, and what meeting planners want next

Doors Open Niagara Falls

13 heritage sites, one free Sunday — October 18



OCTOBER EDITION · COVER STORY

Fashion *in the* Vineyard

Runway, Niagara wine and creative entrepreneurship meet at **Herndler Estate Winery** — November 28

TECHNOLOGY
Robots for the Rest of Us

HEALTH
Ready for Respiratory Season

INVESTMENT
Before the Year Closes

Business Link Media Group

Cover: Fashion in the Vineyard 2026 key art, courtesy of Patience Bitondo Atelier



Marilyn Tian, M.B.A.

President & Co-Publisher

Business Link Media Group

FROM THE PUBLISHER

Publisher's Note

Dear Business Link Readers,

As the harvest wraps up and the fourth quarter begins, this edition of *Business Link* looks at how Niagara presents itself to the world — and how the businesses behind it get ready for what comes next.

COVER STORY

On November 28, Fashion in the Vineyard brings runway, Niagara wine and creative entrepreneurship together at Hernder Estate Winery in St. Catharines. Business Link is proud to be its media and marketing partner.

TOURISM & BUSINESS EVENTS

At Niagara Falls Tourism Connect, the destination reported strong 2026 results and heard directly from meeting planners what it will take to win more corporate and association business.

TECHNOLOGY, HEALTH & INVESTMENT

Three practical guides for the quarter: whether a collaborative robot makes sense for a small shop, how to keep respiratory season from becoming a staffing problem, and the investment and tax questions every owner should settle before December 31.

HERITAGE & STRATEGY

Our illustrated guide to Doors Open Niagara Falls on October 18 walks through all 13 sites, and turnaround specialist Tommy Onich, BBA, CTP, makes the case that resilience starts with reliable data and rigorous cash management.

We hope this issue helps you finish the year strong. Happy reading!

Yours in Business,

Marilyn Tian

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Fashion in the Vineyard



Tourism Connect



Doors Open Niagara Falls

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CULTURE & ENTERPRISE

Fashion in the Vineyard

Where fashion meets wine

On November 28, Niagara will welcome a new kind of evening — one where fashion, wine, creativity and community come together in an experience designed to showcase the region through a distinctly contemporary lens.

Fashion in the Vineyard, presented by Patience Bitondo Atelier, takes place at Hernder Estate Winery in St. Catharines. The event brings together designers, creatives, entrepreneurs, professionals, wine lovers and community leaders for an immersive evening in the heart of Niagara wine country.

More than a runway presentation, Fashion in the Vineyard has been created as a complete experience. Guests will discover a curated runway featuring distinctive designers and collections, alongside Niagara wine and culinary experiences, a carefully selected marketplace, live entertainment and opportunities for meaningful connection. Every element is intended to contribute to an atmosphere that feels refined, welcoming and memorable.

At the heart of the event is a celebration of creative entrepreneurship. Fashion in the Vineyard provides a platform for designers and creative businesses to introduce their work to new audiences while creating space for collaboration, conversation and discovery. It also reflects the growing role that creative industries can play in shaping how a destination is experienced and remembered.

CULTURE & ENTERPRISE *Fashion in the Vineyard*

For Niagara, fashion offers another way to tell the story of the region. The vineyard setting provides more than a backdrop; it becomes part of the experience. Wine, landscape, hospitality, design and local creativity come together in a setting that invites guests to see Niagara beyond the traditional.



Vidal grapes on the vine in Niagara wine country.

Founder and Creative Director Patience Bitondo envisioned Fashion in the Vineyard as an opportunity to bring these worlds together. Through her luxury atelier, Bitondo has built a design practice centred on craftsmanship, considered silhouettes and intentional detail. This event extends that philosophy into a broader cultural experience — one that celebrates both fashion and the people who make Niagara's creative community vibrant.

The event is also an invitation to experience Niagara through design, wine, entrepreneurship and the shared experience of gathering together.

Guests can expect an evening that encourages them to dress up, explore, connect and discover. Whether drawn by fashion, wine, entrepreneurship, culture or simply the desire for an exceptional night out, attendees will experience an event designed to bring people together in a meaningful way.

THE EXPERIENCE

Runway
Distinctive designers & collections

Wine & Culinary
Niagara wine and food

Marketplace
A carefully selected vendor market

Connection
Live entertainment & networking



Niagara wine country in late autumn.

On November 28, the runway meets the vineyard, creativity meets connection, and fashion meets wine.

FASHION IN THE VINEYARD 2026

Saturday, November 28, 2026

Hernder Estate Winery · St. Catharines, Ontario

Tickets: fashionthevineyard.ca

MEDIA / MARKETING PARTNER: **BUSINESS LINK**

SCAN FOR TICKETS



Niagara Falls Sets Its Sights on *Business Events*

At Niagara Falls Tourism Connect, the destination marketing organization reported strong 2026 results and heard directly from meeting planners what it will take to compete for corporate and association business.

Photo: Andrijko Z. / CC BY-SA 3.0

Niagara Falls Tourism Connect · October 6, 2026 · Niagara Falls Convention Centre

Niagara Falls is one of the most recognized destinations in the world. Converting that recognition into year-round business, particularly meetings, conventions and corporate events, was the focus of Niagara Falls Tourism Connect, held October 6 at the Niagara Falls Convention Centre.

Hosted by Niagara Falls Tourism, the afternoon session brought together hoteliers, attraction operators and other industry members with speakers from Destination Canada, the Mastercard Economics Institute and a panel of meeting and event professionals. It concluded with a networking reception.

An industry with local stakes

Adam Stiles, Interim President & CEO of Niagara Falls Tourism, framed tourism in terms of its local economic weight: roughly one in five jobs in the region, a $3-billion industry in Niagara, and approximately 13 million visitors to Niagara Falls each year. Property taxes and casino revenue generated by the sector also help offset the tax burden on residents.

The Hon. Zee Hamid, Ontario's Minister of Tourism, Culture and Gaming, addressed attendees by video, citing the province's strategy to strengthen Niagara as a year-round, world-class destination.

1 in 5	$3B	~13M
JOBS IN THE REGION	TOURISM INDUSTRY IN NIAGARA	VISITORS TO NIAGARA FALLS EACH YEAR

2026 performance

Stiles reported solid returns on the organization's marketing, event and sales investments:

2.4M website sessions during the summer campaign (June 26 to August 18), more than double the previous year

2.7M clicks and landing page views against a forecast of 608,000, at a blended cost of $0.19 per visit versus $0.60 planned

94.0% average hotel occupancy over the September 18–20 weekend of the Niagara 5000 and Misty City Music Festival, up from 87.8%

$2.5M+ in earned media value from a "Thanks for being a neighbour" campaign directed at Buffalo

$12.1M+ in potential revenue, from more than 1,200 client engagements and 23,000 potential room nights generated by the sales team between June and August

Sales activity continues with a mission to Beijing, Shanghai and Seoul in late October, a European mission with Destination Ontario in November, and trade shows including IBTM in Spain. Winter programming, including the Winter Festival of Lights and an extended Hot Chocolate Trail, is designed to sustain visitation through the off-season.

Data as a competitive tool

Joe Amati, Senior Executive Director of Global Market & Brand Intelligence at Destination Canada, presented the Canadian Tourism Data Collective, a free national platform drawing on more than 200 data sources and profiles of more than 5,000 Canadian communities, including Niagara Falls. Its Aurora AI layer allows businesses to query the data in plain language and test marketing concepts against traveller segments defined by values and motivations rather than demographics.

Amati cited Bay of Fundy Adventures, a 12-employee operator that raised summer capacity from 54% to 98% on a marketing budget of approximately $1,000 after applying the segmentation research.



The client panel, from left: Patrick Doyle, Anita Carlyle, Joe Nishi, Paula Seibezzi and Bradley Sutherland.

The economic case for events

Troy David of the Mastercard Economics Institute noted that Canadian consumer spending has remained resilient despite trade tensions and higher energy costs, supported by an unemployment rate that has declined to 6.4% from 7.1% a year earlier. A weaker Canadian dollar, he added, can further support inbound travel.

Mastercard's transaction analysis shows that events generate measurable local gains. Restaurant spending in Calgary rose 29% during the 2025 Stampede, and a June 2026 event in Niagara Falls produced an 11.4% increase in local spending.

The client perspective

A panel moderated by Patrick Doyle, Vice President, Services Business Development, Mastercard Canada, featured Anita Carlyle of Moore Carlyle Consulting / MCC Destination Management, Joe Nishi of Meeting Encore, Paula Seibezzi of HPN Global, and Bradley Sutherland of Air Canada and Meetings Mean Business Canada.

Panellists identified clear advantages: global name recognition, the capacity to accommodate large room blocks, availability when Toronto is constrained, competitive pricing, and a convention centre within walking distance of more than 4,000 hotel rooms.

They were equally direct about the barriers. Niagara Falls is still widely perceived as a leisure destination, and sales materials often reflect that market rather than corporate clients. Panellists also cited transportation access, unpredictable ancillary costs such as resort fees and variable parking rates, and the reputational cost of announced developments that are repeatedly delayed.

FIVE PRIORITIES FROM THE CLIENT PANEL

01 One "Team Niagara"
A unified approach, with a single point of contact and a consistent message

02 Simple contracting
Simple, predictable contracting and pricing for group business

03 Intermediaries
Stronger partnerships with third-party meeting intermediaries, who drive a significant share of group business in Canada

04 Business marketing
Marketing designed for business audiences, distinct from leisure messaging

05 One destination
Regional collaboration that presents Niagara as one destination, across municipal boundaries

Outlook

Speakers agreed that the destination's fundamentals are strong: recognition, infrastructure and growing investment. The opportunity now lies in positioning Niagara Falls as a credible destination for meetings and events, and one that is easy to do business with.

As Niagara Falls Tourism noted in its follow-up to attendees, the event was designed to "share insights, exchange ideas and explore opportunities to grow Niagara Falls as a business events destination."

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INNOVATION & TECHNOLOGY

Robots for the Rest of Us: Is a Cobot Right for Your Shop?

Collaborative robots could help small Canadian manufacturers close the robotics gap, but only if the task, the shift count and the full cost add up.

BY BUSINESS LINK

In 2022, just 1.6% of Canadian firms with 10 to 99 employees used robotics. Among large firms the figure was 9.1%.

Those numbers come from Statistics Canada's Survey of Advanced Technology, published in August 2024. Manufacturing led every sector, with 8.4% of firms using robotics, and Ontario led the regions at 3.0%. But for small shops, robots were still the exception.

The gap matters more now, with U.S. tariffs pressuring manufacturers and recruiting a common complaint. Collaborative robots, or "cobots," are often pitched as an entry point for smaller manufacturers. Whether one suits your floor depends on three things: the task, the hours you run and an honest look at the full system cost.

What a cobot is, and isn't

A cobot is a robot arm designed to work near people. Force limiting means it can often run without a full safety cage. Staff can usually program it by guiding the arm by hand or through a simple interface. It still needs a safety risk assessment before it enters production.

Cobots are a steady part of the market, not a takeover. "New collaborative robot (cobot) installations reached 66,000 units, representing 11% of all industrial robot installations," Jane Heffner, President of the International Federation of Robotics (IFR), said of 2025. She noted that cobot growth of 7% fell below that of the industrial robot market, the first time since the IFR began tracking cobots.

Canada installed just under 4,000 industrial robots in 2025, up 5%, according to the IFR. Nearly half (47%) of Canadian installs in 2024 were in automotive.

Good first jobs are bounded and repetitive: palletizing, machine tending, inspection, end-of-line case packing, and bottle and case handling. At Raumland, a German wine-bottling firm, a cobot palletizes cartons at the end of the bottling line, with a stored program for each customer, according to a robot maker's case study.

The real math

> *"Start with the task and the math, not the machine."*

Prices are where the sales pitch and the shop floor often part ways. The only figures available come from vendors and consultants, who have a stake in the answer. Treat them as estimates, quoted in U.S. dollars.

By those estimates, a bare cobot arm starts at about $30,000. An entry-level palletizing cell runs about $60,000 to $160,000. The whole cell usually costs far more than the arm once tooling, guarding, integration and programming are added.

One vendor quotes payback of 12 to 18 months for cobot systems. Payback depends on hours of use, so a cell on a single shift, which describes many small shops, should be expected to take longer.

Firms already using robotics name the same hurdles. In the survey, 25.2% rated difficulty recruiting qualified staff a significant obstacle, as did 21.4% for low return on investment, 20.2% for lack of employee training, 19.6% for difficulty accessing financial support and 19.5% for integration with existing systems. Someone has to maintain the cell, reprogram it when a product changes and bring the crew along.

Paying for it

The federal program many small firms used for technology projects is gone. The technology-adoption stream of the Canada Digital Adoption Program (CDAP) stopped taking applications in February 2024, and the program was scheduled to end in March 2025. No like-for-like federal grant has replaced it.

The biggest pot of money open in 2026 is tariff-response funding, not an automation grant. The Federal Economic Development Agency for Southern Ontario (FedDev Ontario) is accepting Regional Tariff Response Initiative (RTRI) applications from tariff-affected businesses with at least $1 million in annual revenue. Pivot projects can receive up to $1 million non-repayable, covering up to 50% of costs. FedDev Ontario's page does not list eligible costs, so don't assume it covers a cobot.

RTRI has funded equipment in Niagara. On July 28, 2026, in Thorold, FedDev Ontario announced more than $11.3 million for 13 Niagara firms, including Canada Perforating, Black Creek Metal and VTR Feeder Solutions. High Strength Plates & Profiles of Thorold received up to $750,000 toward a $1.5 million project for advanced equipment.

Two other federal doors are worth knowing. The National Research Council's Industrial Research Assistance Program (IRAP) has more than 250 industrial technology advisors and funds technology-driven innovation, but offers more advice than subsidy for off-the-shelf equipment. NGen, the industry-led advanced manufacturing cluster, funds large, often collaborative projects. We found no open call at press time; check ngen.ca for current intakes.

On the tax side, legislation passed in March 2026 restored a 100% first-year write-off for manufacturing and processing machinery acquired from 2025 and available for use before 2030. Check with your accountant whether a specific cell qualifies.

Where to start

Pick one task. Choose a job that is repetitive, well defined and hard to staff, such as end-of-line palletizing or loading a machine. Don't automate a whole line at once.

Count your hours. A cell that runs one shift pays back far more slowly than one running two or three. Build the case on the hours you actually run.

Price the whole cell. Get quotes that include tooling, guarding, integration, programming and training, not just the arm.

Plan for people. Decide who will own the cell, what training they need and how you'll explain the change to the crew.

Talk to WAMIC. Niagara College's Walker Advanced Manufacturing Innovation Centre (WAMIC) in Welland is a technology access centre for small and mid-sized manufacturers. In 2024, the Natural Sciences and Engineering Research Council (NSERC) renewed its funding at $1.75 million over five years. Its services include digital manufacturing, precision metrology, prototype design and development, and process improvement. Applied research partners like WAMIC can help test an idea before you commit capital.

A robot won't fix a staffing problem by itself, and the money available today is aimed mainly at tariff recovery. For a small manufacturer with one clear, repetitive bottleneck and realistic numbers, a first cobot is now a practical question rather than a far-off one. Start with the task and the math, not the machine.

KEY POINTS

- In 2022, just 1.6% of Canadian firms with 10 to 99 employees used robotics, compared with 9.1% of large firms (Statistics Canada).
- Price the whole cell, not the arm: tooling, guarding and integration add up, and fewer shifts mean a longer payback.
- Cobots made up 11% of global robot installs in 2025, but their growth trailed the overall market for the first time.
- CDAP is closed. RTRI is tariff-response funding, IRAP is mainly advisory, and WAMIC in Welland offers local manufacturing help.

THE BOTTOM LINE

For a small manufacturer, a first cobot makes sense when it targets one repetitive bottleneck and the full cell cost works on the shifts you actually run.



HERITAGE & COMMUNITY

Sunday, October 18, 2026 · 11 a.m. – 5 p.m.

Discover Niagara Falls' Heritage at *Doors Open*

Niagara Falls History Museum, the former Stamford Township Hall. Photo: Mhsheikholeslami / CC BY-SA 4.0

13	1	$0	6
PARTICIPATING SITES	DAY: SUNDAY, OCT. 18	ADMISSION AT EVERY SITE	HOURS: 11 A.M. – 5 P.M.

Explore the buildings, places and stories that help shape Niagara Falls during **Doors Open Niagara Falls on Sunday, October 18, 2026, from 11 a.m. to 5 p.m.** Organized by the City of Niagara Falls Municipal Heritage Committee as part of the province-wide Doors Open Ontario program, the free, one-day event invites residents and visitors to discover 13 participating sites across the city.

From historic churches and a War of 1812 battlefield to museums, cultural spaces and buildings finding new purpose, select locations will offer guided tours, demonstrations and opportunities to speak with the people who care for these places.

WHAT TO EXPECT

- ✓ Guided tours and demonstrations at select sites
- ✓ Curator tours at the History Museum at 11 a.m. and 2 p.m.
- ✓ Music, dancing and food at St. Mary's parish hall
- ✓ Water Treatment Plant tours by advance registration only

> *Heritage is not just about preserving the past; it is about inspiring the future.*
>
> **DAVID SERVOS UE** · CHAIR, DOORS OPEN NIAGARA FALLS

DOORS OPEN NIAGARA FALLS *The 13 sites at a glance*

13 Sites, One Free Sunday


Photo: Mhsheikholeslami / CC BY-SA 4.0
Battle of Chippawa National Historic Site


Photo: Bmarchessault / CC BY-SA 3.0
Ten Thousand Buddhas Sarira Stupa


Photo: Mykola Swarnyk / CC BY-SA 4.0
St. Mary's Ukrainian Catholic Church

01 **Battle of Chippawa National Historic Site**
The preserved 1814 battlefield, with interpretive storyboards.

02 **Chippawa Town Hall**
An 1842 civic landmark being restored for new uses.

03 **Cummington Square & Bandshell**
War memorials, a recreated 1920s bandstand and Doors Open volunteers.

04 **Holy Trinity Anglican Church, Chippawa**
A congregation dating to 1820 that included Laura Secord.

05 **Niagara Falls (Chippawa) Water Treatment Plant**
One-hour guided tours; advance registration required.

06 **Niagara Military Museum & Armoury**
Local military history inside the 1911 armoury.

07 **Niagara Falls Rankin Innovation Hub**
Former customs offices now supporting entrepreneurs; tours and demos.

08 **Ten Thousand Buddhas Sarira Stupa**
Traditional Chinese architecture and 10,000 Buddha statues.

09 **Old St. John's Church & Stamford Green Columbarium**
Gothic Revival, built in 1825 and restored as a columbarium.

10 **Niagara Falls History Museum**
Interactive exhibits and War of 1812 artifacts; curator tours.

11 **St. Mary's Ukrainian Catholic Church**
Ukrainian architecture and iconography; music and food in the hall.

12 **The Niagara Falls Exchange**
The City's arts and culture hub, with studios, gallery and café.

13 **Stamford Presbyterian Church**
Worshipping on this site since 1791; historical display.

PLAN YOUR VISIT

Admission is free. Check each site's listing for hours, accessibility and tour requirements at doorsopenontario.on.ca. **Water Treatment Plant tours:** register in advance at wwwtours@niagararegion.ca — no drop-ins; wear closed-toe shoes and long pants. Make a weekend of it with Doors Open Niagara-on-the-Lake on Saturday, October 17.

More information: Julie Hannah, Manager of Policy Planning, City of Niagara Falls · jhannah@niagarafalls.ca

Scan or tap for site listings & hours



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BUSINESS STRATEGY

Preparing for *Adversity*



By
Tommy Onich, BBA, CTP
President, TCMI Limited

Businesses are now facing a level of difficulty and uncertainty that has not been seen in decades. The United States has begun an erratic and unreasoned attack upon world trade through tariffs that are being applied worldwide. Their proposed tariff policy has been frequently and capriciously changed, sometimes within a day. This has caused tremendous fear and uncertainty for business, investors, and individuals alike.

All of these stakeholders face a level of economic peril and uncertainty not seen for generations. This situation has been recently exacerbated by war in the Middle East. The combination of a destructive tariff policy and war make the chances of a global recession likely.

THE THREE CRITERIA FOR REVERSING A BUSINESS'S FORTUNES

Financial resources

the cash necessary for change — the lifeblood of the organization

Quality management

leadership built on relevant, reliable and timely data

A viable product

a viable core product at the heart of the business

BUSINESS STRATEGY *Preparing for Adversity*

All businesses and their stakeholders have little insight into coming events and their effects. Uncertainty is the very essence of our current environment.

For such issues as sales, product pricing, cost inputs, and availability of raw materials little is known. This lack of insight is compounded by the fact that time is of the essence and adversity is certainly fast approaching.

It is worth exploring just what can be done to face the coming storm. This involves exploring the criteria necessary for a business that is experiencing difficulty or distress to reverse its fortunes. These are: *financial resources necessary for change, quality management, and a viable product.*

It is axiomatic that a business with significant deficiencies today will not be able to meet an imminent challenge. It is also possible to improve sufficiently to meet such a challenge.

Data Quality

The foundation of good management lies in quality of data. Data that is relevant, reliable, and timely. This is the very foundation of Performance Management, which provides a platform for resilience and a foundation for growth.



The three tests every number in your business should pass

Most companies have some deficiencies with respect to the quality of information. In those companies already facing distress, data is often incorrect, incomplete, misrepresented or just plain wrong.

Cash / MIS

Cash is the lifeblood of any organization. It permits day-to-day operations, allows the organization to meet daily obligations, face adversity and take advantage of opportunity.

Implicit goals of cash management include improving the quality of MIS and accounting and providing information useful in meeting adversity. This will include insight concerning details of financial performance and opportunities for both cost reduction and growth. It is also an important step in seeking new capital.

Control is the first goal. It is important that all authority for disbursement resides with as few people as possible. Anyone on this list must be experienced in an exigent environment.

In our current environment, at any given time a significant cash deficiency may result in catastrophe. It is better to exercise control in excess than insufficiently.

THE EXPLICIT GOALS OF CASH MANAGEMENT

01 Control disbursement

02 Enhance revenue and decrease costs

03 Determine flows

04 Husband resources

"It is better to exercise control in excess than insufficiently."

FROM FIRST LINE OF DEFENCE TO FULL PROJECTION

Daily
Revenue, disbursements, bank position and float. Looks forward a few weeks; expected to be very accurate.

Monthly
Prepared as data is gathered, tested and refined.

Yearly
Accurate history plus a well-reasoned estimate of the future.

The cash budget and projection are the primary tools necessary for cash management. They are an accurate record of historical revenues and expenses, a well-reasoned estimate of the future, and much more.

Properly completed, these tools achieve the explicit goals of cash management. They also yield rich dividends in the decision-making process by providing great insight concerning the criteria for success: *cash resources, management and a viable core product.*

THE CASH BUDGET AND PROJECTION WILL:

- ✓ Assist in the determination of available cash resources
- ✓ Quickly outline opportunities for cost reduction and revenue enhancement
- ✓ Yield insights into accounting and MIS deficiencies
- ✓ Provide accurate historical data and assist with pro forma planning under different scenarios
- ✓ Provide a breakdown of revenue and expense in detail by product, division, etc.
- ✓ Provide insights into the long-term viability of the firm
- ✓ Enhance the capability for market planning
- ✓ Yield information that is viable in a variety of management reports

The preparation of the cash budget is an evolutionary and recursive process.

Often cash is immediately problematic and a simple report must be prepared ad hoc with a very short look forward. This will likely be a daily cash report.

In a simple format it includes revenue, disbursements, bank position, and float. It looks forward a few weeks and is expected to be very accurate. It is the first line of defence against disaster and quickly delineates priorities. As data is gathered, tested and refined, monthly and yearly reports are prepared.

Testing the Numbers

The establishment of an independent test center provides autonomous verification that data is reliable. The use of testing will optimize the quality of data. Operationally, the center also assists with the correction of accounting and MIS deficiencies while the budget process is ongoing.

Testing will also provide an independent review of assumptions used in the formulation of pro forma revenue and expense.

Testing includes proof of revenue and expense tests and also includes some balance sheet items such as hidden collateral, non-performing assets and past due liabilities. Testing begins with a basic or cursory evaluation and can be increased to a forensic level as needed.

It is important to note that the budget process yields benefits even before it is complete. These include revealing opportunities for cost reduction or revenue enhancement. They will also provide insight concerning sales, marketing and potential additional products.

Completion of the budget does not prevent management from exploiting opportunities. Planning and action are not mutually exclusive. Quick, positive action should not be encumbered by excessive analysis.

"Planning and action are not mutually exclusive."

Unlocking Cash

Concurrently, it is important to seek additional cash from all sources. Unlocking cash requires a current and accurate balance sheet. Potential capital sources include:

- Sale of non-performing assets
- Amending terms of outstanding debt
- Collection of past due accounts
- Statutory or non-statutory restructuring
- Additional debt
- Amending terms on A/P or A/R

The balance sheet must be completed with a critical eye. The following steps will assist in a correct valuation:

- ✓ The visual inspection and inventory of all tangible assets at all locations — including plant, equipment, vehicles, real estate and inventory
- ✓ An inventory of all tangible assets including A/R, patents, trademarks, leases and interests in other entities
- ✓ An appraisal of assets based upon orderly liquidation
- ✓ Verification from source for all loans, mortgages, and financial liabilities
- ✓ Particular attention to third-party liabilities and contingent liabilities

The establishment of cash controls and properly prepared projections will provide great insight concerning the criteria necessary to face adversity.

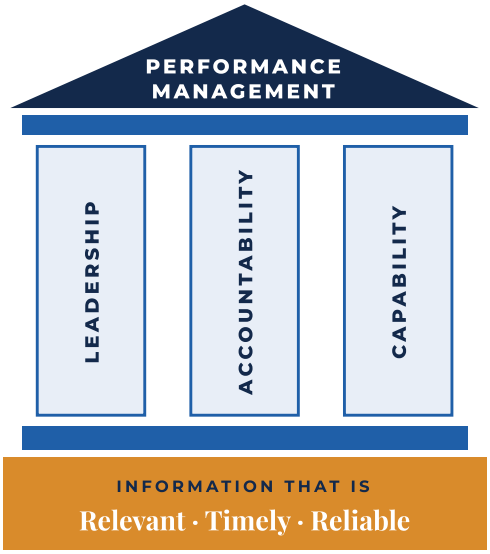
Performance Management

This is the platform which will provide an organization with resilience and a foundation for recovery.

A lack of rigour surrounding cash management is one of the key symptoms that a culture of Performance Management is lacking. Additional symptoms include poor controls, a disconnect between financial measurements and performance drivers, and a lack of corporate discipline and accountability.

The core elements of Performance Management are Leadership, Accountability, and Capability. These elements must have as their base information that is Relevant, Timely, and Reliable.

Achieving the goals set for cash management will provide a platform for businesses to develop a culture of Performance Management, providing resilience in the face of adversity and a platform for future growth.



The core elements of Performance Management rest on a foundation of quality information.

WARNING SIGNS

- Lack of rigour in cash management
- Poor controls
- Financial measures disconnected from performance drivers
- Lack of corporate discipline and accountability

Summary

Canadian businesses now face a level of adversity that has not been seen in many years.

In the face of an impending economic downturn it is important to evaluate the *current viability* of the company in light of three criteria for success. These are: *cash, management and a viable core product.*

Cash is the very lifeblood of the organization. It provides resources for day-to-day operations and the strength to face adversity. It is essential to ensure that the cash management process is rigorous. It is also necessary to create cash projections looking forward.

In addition to conserving and enhancing cash as a resource, this process will yield a great deal of information concerning the fundamental viability of the firm. It will also provide the foundation for a culture of Performance Management.

FIVE MOVES TO MAKE THIS QUARTER

01
Test your data.
Make sure the numbers you manage by are relevant, reliable and timely.

02
Tighten disbursement authority.
Keep it with as few experienced people as possible.

03
Start a daily cash report.
Revenue, disbursements, bank position and float — a few weeks out.

04
Build the cash budget and projection.
Let it evolve from daily to monthly to yearly.

05
Look for cash everywhere.
Revisit assets, debt terms, receivables and payables.

Key points drawn from the article above.



ABOUT THE AUTHOR

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TCMI MANAGEMENT CONSULTING FOR CORPORATE RENEWAL

Tom has been the president of his own consulting firm, TCMI Limited, since 2003. TCMI is a provider of management, consulting, turnaround or crisis management, corporate restructuring, and renewal services to companies in financial and operational difficulty.

Tom is a specialist in interim and crisis management with over 20 years of senior management experience in financial, operational, and statutory restructuring. He has served as Chief Restructuring Officer, Chief Executive Officer, and Chief Financial Officer in a wide range of business sectors including health care, structural steel, garment manufacturing, yacht building, die cast, railroad repair and food processing. He is recognized for his achievements in statutory restructuring, cash flow management, creditor negotiations, management assessment, performance management, corporate strategy or business planning, organizational assessment, and corporate due diligence. Tom has successfully restructured organizations through informal arrangements with creditors and by statute, and is one of the few turnaround professionals experienced with the insolvency regimes of both Canada and the United States. Prior to his work in corporate renewal, he was engaged in corporate lending with a major Canadian bank, winning several awards for innovative solutions tailored to clients' needs.

Tom completed the stringent accreditation process of the Association of Turnaround Professionals and was awarded the Certified Turnaround Professional designation in 2001. He holds a Bachelor of Business Administration with Honours from Brock University. His articles have been published in the *Journal of Corporate Renewal*, *The Secured Lender*, *The Commercial Lending Review*, *Canadian Small Business Magazine*, and *The Provider*.

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PathstoneMentalHealth.ca/Hope

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HEALTH & WORKFORCE

Ready for Respiratory Season: A Workplace Playbook

Flu, COVID-19 and RSV programs are rolling out and the sick-note rules changed in 2024, so October is the time to set a sick policy, make vaccines easy to get and check the air.

BY BUSINESS LINK

Canadians lost about 10.5 days per person to illness or disability in 2024, according to an iA Financial Group analysis of Statistics Canada data. That number covers every kind of illness and injury, not just colds and flu. But anyone who has run a shop floor, a front counter or a small office through January knows how quickly one bad week can spread through a team.

Respiratory season is here. Ontario has started its fall flu, COVID-19 and RSV programs, and the sick-note rules changed in 2024. For Niagara businesses, the practical question is not whether people will get sick this winter. It is how to keep a cough from becoming a staffing problem.

Employers have three levers: a clear sick policy, easy access to vaccines and cleaner indoor air. None needs to cost much, and all work better if they're in place before the first wave.

This is general business guidance, not medical advice. Employees with health questions should talk to their health care provider or call Health811.

What's available this fall

In a September 25 announcement, the Ontario government set out its fall respiratory programs. Priority groups were first in line from the week of September 28 (flu shots at pharmacies from the week of October 13): hospital patients and staff, residents and staff of long-term care homes, retirement homes and other congregate settings, and adults 65 and older.

The same announcement says free flu and COVID-19 shots will open to the general public on October 26 at participating pharmacies, public health units and participating doctor and nurse practitioner offices. Supply varies by provider, so the province advises calling ahead. People can ask about flu and COVID-19 shots, and RSV if eligible, at the same visit.

RSV vaccine is publicly funded for Ontario residents 75 and older, and for those 60 to 74 who meet high-risk criteria or live in higher-risk settings. For employees with a new baby, RSV protection for infants in their first RSV season began October 1, and an RSV vaccine can be given during pregnancy.

Locally, Niagara Region Public Health offers publicly funded vaccines. Check with the Region directly for current clinic locations, hours and booking before you point staff there. Health811 can also help people find a provider.

Sick days without the sick note

> *"The practical question is not whether people will get sick this winter. It is how to keep a cough from becoming a staffing problem."*

Under Ontario's Employment Standards Act (ESA), employees get up to three unpaid, job-protected sick days per calendar year once they've worked for an employer for two consecutive weeks. Unused days don't carry over and aren't pro-rated. If an employee takes part of a day, it may count as a full day. Telling the employer verbally is enough notice.

The bigger change for many managers is that since October 28, 2024, employers can't require a note from a doctor or other qualified health practitioner for ESA sick leave, according to the province's ESA guide. Employers can still ask for evidence that's reasonable in the circumstances, such as a signed attestation from the employee. Medical notes can still be requested for other purposes, such as accommodation or return to work.

That changes the approach. With the note gone, the written policy does more of the work. Spell out:

- ✓ how to report an absence, to whom and by what time;
- ✓ what attestation, if any, you will ask for;
- ✓ whether staff who feel able to work, but shouldn't be around others, can work from home where the job allows;
- ✓ who covers critical roles when someone is out.

The goal is a policy that makes staying home the obvious choice when someone is sick. The Public Health Agency of Canada lists staying home when sick among its protective measures, alongside vaccination, hand hygiene, ventilation and masks. If people come in sick because they're unsure of the rules or afraid of falling behind, the policy isn't doing its job.

Review it with supervisors now, so the person taking a 6 a.m. call-in knows what to say.

Make the shot the easy choice

Vaccination is voluntary, and making it a condition of work raises legal questions. Talk to HR or legal counsel before going that route. Employers can instead remove the friction.

Share the dates. Put the general-public start date and the Health811 number on the break-room board and in a payroll or team email.

Give people time. A pharmacy visit takes time out of someone's day. Letting staff book shots during work hours or swap shifts to make it possible removes one reason people put it off.

Point to nearby options. Pharmacies, public health clinics and family doctors or nurse practitioners are all part of the provincial program. Because supply varies, suggest employees call ahead.

Consider bringing it on site. Larger workplaces may be able to arrange an on-site clinic. Providers and costs vary, so ask early.

Clear the air

Air quality is the easiest lever to overlook. Health Canada's guidance on indoor air quality in office buildings says that when respiratory illness is circulating, ventilation systems should run for two hours at maximum outdoor airflow before and after the building is occupied. It also recommends MERV 13 or higher filters where feasible.

Most small businesses won't know what their system can handle, and that's fine. Ask your HVAC contractor or property manager three things: what filters are installed now, whether the system can take MERV 13 and whether run times can be extended around opening and closing.

Before the first wave

None of this guarantees a healthy winter. But a written sick policy, a reminder about the general-public vaccine start date and a call to the HVAC contractor can all be done this month. Waiting until a third of the team is out sick in January will cost far more.

KEY POINTS

- Ontario's flu and COVID-19 shots open to the general public October 26 at participating pharmacies, public health units and providers' offices.
- Employers can still ask for reasonable evidence, such as a signed attestation, so set absence-reporting rules in writing.
- Since October 28, 2024, employers can't require a doctor's note for the three unpaid ESA sick days.
- Make shots easy by sharing dates and allowing booking time, and ask your HVAC contractor about MERV 13 filters and longer run times.

THE BOTTOM LINE

A clear sick policy, easy vaccine access and better ventilation, all in place this month, are low-cost ways to keep respiratory season from becoming a staffing problem.



FINANCE & INVESTMENT

Before the Year Closes: Investment Questions for Owner-Managers

The big tax-policy questions have settled, so year-end planning comes down to checking dates, limits and the $50,000 line, then taking your questions to an accountant.

BY BUSINESS LINK

The last day to sell a losing investment and have the loss count for 2026 isn't December 31. Based on the TMX settlement calendar, it's Wednesday, December 30.

That date is one of several Niagara owner-managers can still act on in the 11 weeks left in the year. The big tax-policy questions of the past two years have settled, so planning this fall is less about guessing and more about checking the numbers.

What follows is general information, not tax or investment advice. Bring each item to your accountant or advisor.

The proposed increase in the capital gains inclusion rate, from one-half to two-thirds, was cancelled by Prime Minister Mark Carney on March 21, 2025. The rate remains 50%.

According to accounting-firm summaries of Budget 2025, tabled November 4, 2025, the budget also cancelled the Canadian Entrepreneurs' Incentive, which had proposed cutting the inclusion rate to one-third on up to $2 million of gains.

The higher lifetime capital gains exemption (LCGE) is now law. The increase to $1.25 million of eligible capital gains, effective June 25, 2024, was included in Bill C-15, which received Royal Assent on March 26, 2026. If a sale or succession is on your horizon, ask whether your shares would qualify.

One caution: a fall economic statement could change these measures. We had not found a date for one at press time.

YEAR-END DATES & LIMITS	
TFSA annual limit	$7,000
RRSP dollar limit	$33,810
Capital gains inclusion rate	50%
Lifetime capital gains exemption	$1.25 million
Federal passive income threshold	$50,000 (nil at $150,000)
FHSA annual room	$8,000
Last trade date for 2026 settlement	Wed., Dec. 30
Bank of Canada rate / next decision	2.25% / Oct. 28

Personal accounts: room you can still use

For 2026, the TFSA annual limit is $7,000, unchanged from 2025, and the RRSP dollar limit is $33,810, up from $32,490, according to the Canada Revenue Agency (CRA). Your RRSP deduction limit is generally the lesser of 18% of the previous year's earned income and the dollar limit, plus unused room.

> *"Planning this fall is less about guessing and more about checking the numbers."*

Salary creates earned income for RRSP purposes and builds CPP entitlement, but it also triggers payroll contributions. For 2026, the CPP rate is 5.95% on earnings up to $74,600 (maximum $4,230.45), plus a 4% second contribution (CPP2) on earnings between $74,600 and $85,000 (maximum $416). The employer matches both. Dividends don't draw CPP contributions.

There's no single right mix. Dividends don't count as earned income for RRSP room, so ask your accountant what balance fits your income and plans.

If you are saving for a first home, the First Home Savings Account (FHSA) offers $8,000 of annual participation room, up to $40,000 over your lifetime. Contributions count for the calendar year, so make them by December 31, and confirm with the CRA how unused room carries forward.

Inside the corporation: watch the $50,000 line

Many owners build savings inside their corporation, but federally that comes with a limit.

The small business limit for a Canadian-controlled private corporation (CCPC) is normally $500,000. When the corporation and its associated corporations have more than $50,000 of adjusted aggregate investment income, the federal limit shrinks by $5 for every $1 over that line, reaching zero at $150,000, according to the CRA. The test looks at the prior year's investment income, so what the company's portfolio earns this year can affect next year's limit.

Ontario is different. The CRA states that Ontario's small business limit is not subject to the federal passive income reduction. That softens the impact but doesn't remove it: the federal reduction still raises federal tax on active business income.

Questions for your accountant: How close is the company to the $50,000 threshold? Would moving some savings into personal accounts change the picture? Is an individual pension plan (IPP) worth a look?

Selling at a loss: mind the calendar

Selling investments that have dropped in value can produce capital losses to offset gains. For a loss to count in 2026, the trade must settle by December 31.

Most Canadian and U.S. stock trades settle one business day after the trade date (T+1). TSX markets are closed Friday, December 25, and Monday, December 28. So a trade on Wednesday, December 30 settles December 31. A trade on December 31 won't settle until January 4, 2027. Foreign-listed securities and mutual funds may differ, so confirm cut-offs with your broker.

Watch the superficial loss rule. Buying the same security within 30 days before or after the sale denies the loss for now; it is generally added to the cost of the replacement shares. The rule extends to affiliated persons, including a company you or your spouse control, so ask your accountant who counts in your situation.

Rates, and a warning about scams

The Bank of Canada's policy rate is 2.25% after a hold on September 2. The next decision is scheduled for October 28, and the final announcement of 2026 is December 9. The October outcome wasn't known at press time.

Investment fraud was the costliest scam category in Canada in 2025, at $351 million of $704 million in reported losses, according to the Canadian Anti-Fraud Centre (CAFC). It led again in the first half of 2026, at about $139.6 million.

A 2024 Ontario Securities Commission (OSC) study found that participants in an online simulation invested 22% more in AI-enhanced scams than in conventional ones.

Before investing with anyone new, check their registration through the OSC's Check Before You Invest resource.

None of this calls for a big decision today. It does call for a calendar: book the accountant meeting before December, bring these questions, and leave room for whatever Ottawa or the Bank of Canada announces.

KEY POINTS

- Capital gains inclusion stays at 50%, and the $1.25 million lifetime capital gains exemption became law in March 2026.
- Federal small business limit shrinks above $50,000 of passive income. Ontario's limit isn't reduced, but federal tax still rises.
- 2026 personal limits: TFSA $7,000, RRSP $33,810. Investments held inside your corporation don't use this room.
- The last trade date for 2026 settlement is December 30, based on the TMX calendar. Confirm with your broker.

THE BOTTOM LINE

The big rules have settled, so use the weeks left in 2026 to check your room, your passive income and your trade dates with an accountant before December 30.

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OCTOBER 16 – NOVEMBER 15, 2026

Dates to Know

Business, heritage and culture across the Niagara Region over the next four weeks.

FRI 16 OCT

South Niagara Auction Gala

Americana Conference Resort, Niagara Falls · 6–10 p.m.

South Niagara Chamber of Commerce fundraising gala; proceeds support local student scholarships.

southniagaracc.com

SAT 17 OCT

Doors Open Niagara-on-the-Lake

16 sites, Niagara-on-the-Lake · 10 a.m. – 5 p.m.

Niagara-on-the-Lake's edition of the province-wide Doors Open Ontario program, from Navy Hall to RiverBrink.

doorsopenontario.on.ca

SUN 18 OCT

Doors Open Niagara Falls

13 sites across Niagara Falls · 11 a.m. – 5 p.m.

Free admission to historic churches, a War of 1812 battlefield, museums and cultural spaces.

Read our guide, page 12

MON–SUN 19–25 OCT

BDC Small Business Week

Across Canada and online

BDC's annual week of events and resources for entrepreneurs; watch local chambers for Niagara sessions.

bdc.ca/small-business-week

SUN 25 OCT

Niagara Falls Marathon

Niagara Falls

The annual marathon and related races finish in Niagara Falls; expect road closures on race morning.

niagarafallsmarathon.com

SUN 25 OCT

Unmasking Hope: A High Tea Affair

The Garden Pavilion, Club Roma

Pathstone Mental Health's high tea fundraiser, with general admission and VIP Coronation tickets.

PathstoneMentalHealth.ca/Hope

TUE 27 OCT

Multi-Chamber Business After Five

Niagara District Airport, Niagara-on-the-Lake · 5–7 p.m.

Networking for members of five Niagara chambers, with a look at airport upgrades.

southniagaracc.com

THU 29 OCT

Hamilton 40 Under Forty Awards Gala

Carmen's Event Centre, Hamilton · 5–9:30 p.m.

Business Link's 13th annual 40U40 Business Achievement Awards. Ticket sales end October 16.

Tickets & details, page 25

FRI 30 OCT

Niagara Economic Summit 2026

Greater Niagara Chamber of Commerce · 7:30 a.m. – 3 p.m.

The region's annual economic forum. Venue and registration details from the chamber.

gncc.ca/events

TUE 3 NOV

GNCC Business After 5

Greater Niagara Chamber of Commerce · 5–7 p.m.

The chamber's monthly after-work networking event. Check the chamber listing for the host venue.

gncc.ca/events

FROM THU 5 NOV

A Year with Frog and Toad

Shaw Festival, Niagara-on-the-Lake · to Dec. 23

The Shaw's holiday musical based on Arnold Lobel's books; recommended for ages 6 and up.

shawfest.com

FRI 6 NOV

Women in Business Awards

Greater Niagara Chamber of Commerce · 11 a.m. – 2:30 p.m.

The chamber's annual awards celebrating women leaders and entrepreneurs across Niagara.

gncc.ca/events

THU 12 NOV

Ruby Awards

Lookout Point Country Club · 9–10:30 a.m.

Morning event recognizing Welland and Pelham individuals and businesses for leadership and community contributions.

southniagaracc.com

SAT 14 NOV

Niagara Falls Santa Claus Parade

Victoria Avenue to City Hall, Niagara Falls · 4 p.m.

The City's annual Santa Claus Parade kicks off the holiday season downtown.

niagarafalls.ca

SUN 15 NOV

Deck the Halls Holiday Market

Niagara Falls Exchange & History Museum · 11 a.m. – 5 p.m.

A holiday market at two City cultural venues, with local makers and seasonal shopping.

niagarafalls.ca

SAT 28 NOV

SAVE THE DATE · OUR COVER STORY

Fashion in the Vineyard

Runway, Niagara wine and a vendor marketplace at Hernder Estate Winery, St. Catharines, presented by Patience Bitondo Atelier. Read the story, page 04

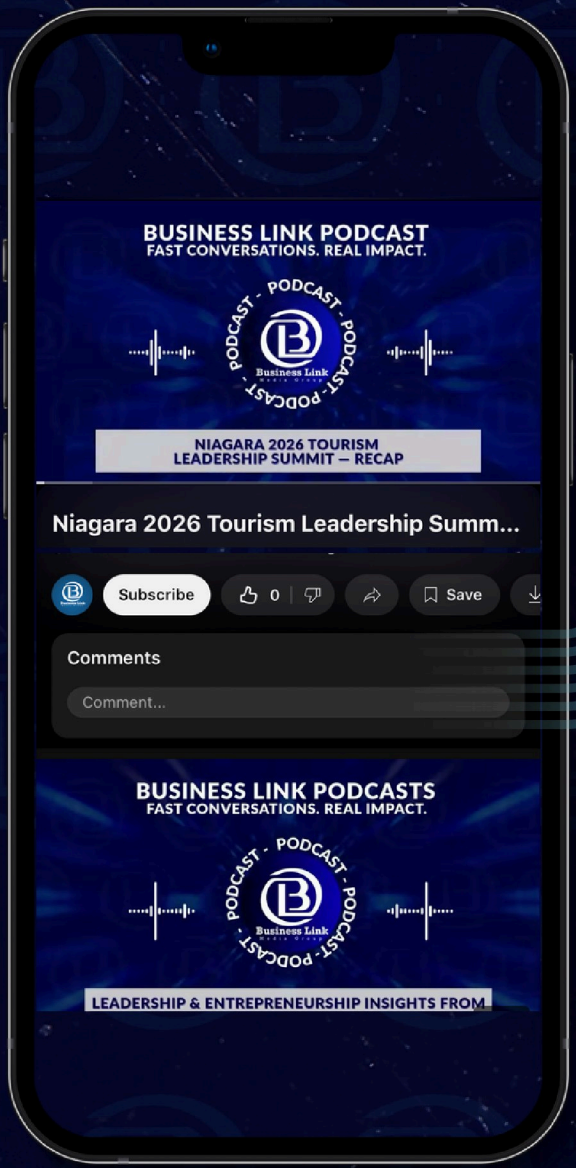
Dates and details are compiled from organizer listings as of October 14, 2026, and are subject to change. Please confirm with organizers before attending. Have an event for our calendar? Email info@businesslinkmedia.com.

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The Business Link AI-Powered Podcast explores the ideas, people, and events shaping our regional business community. Using AI-driven commentary, each episode reviews key business developments, industry trends, and highlights leaders making an impact across the region.

Rather than traditional interviews, the podcast provides insightful overviews and perspectives on business news, events, and initiatives featured across Business Link Media platforms.



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Sources, Credits & Contributors

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- "Fashion in the Vineyard" feature and key art (cover and page 04) supplied by Patience Bitondo Atelier. Business Link is the event's media / marketing partner. Tickets: fashionin thevineyard.ca

TOURISM & BUSINESS EVENTS

- Report on Niagara Falls Tourism Connect, October 6, 2026, Niagara Falls Convention Centre, hosted by Niagara Falls Tourism. Article text and client-panel photo supplied for publication.

INNOVATION & TECHNOLOGY

- Statistics Canada, Survey of Advanced Technology, 2022 (statcan.gc.ca) · International Federation of Robotics, World Robotics 2026 releases (ifr.org) · FedDev Ontario, Niagara RTRI announcement, July 28, 2026 (canada.ca) · NRC IRAP (nrc.canada.ca) · Finance Canada, Budget 2025 implementation (canada.ca) · Niagara College WAMIC / NSERC renewal (niagaracollege.ca)

HEALTH & WORKFORCE

- Government of Ontario, fall respiratory program, September 25, 2026 · Ontario, *Your guide to the ESA*: sick leave (ontario.ca) · Health Canada, indoor air quality in office buildings (canada.ca) · PHAC, personal protective measures (canada.ca) · iA Financial Group analysis of StatCan Table 14-10-0196-01

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- Canada Revenue Agency: 2026 RRSP/TFSA limits, CPP and CPP2 rates, FHSA, T4040, Ontario small business deduction (canada.ca/cra) · Bank of Canada, key interest rate and schedule (bankofcanada.ca) · TMX, 2026 holiday settlement calendar (tsx.com) · Canadian Anti-Fraud Centre (antifraudcentre.ca) · Ontario Securities Commission, 2024 AI-scams study

HERITAGE & STRATEGY

- City of Niagara Falls, Municipal Heritage Committee — Doors Open news release (media contact: Julie Hannah) · Doors Open Ontario listings (doorsopenontario.on.ca) · "Preparing for Adversity" by Tommy Onich, BBA, CTP, TCMI Limited — contributed; opinions are the author's own.

DATES TO KNOW

- Organizer listings as of October 14, 2026: South Niagara Chamber of Commerce, Greater Niagara Chamber of Commerce, BDC, Doors Open Ontario, Niagara Falls Marathon, Shaw Festival, City of Niagara Falls, Pathstone Mental Health, Business Link Media Group (Hamilton 40U40 gala, page 25).

ADVERTISERS IN THIS ISSUE

- Triple Automation — page 09 · Flight Centre Corporate Benefits — page 14 · Pathstone Mental Health — page 20

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